

ANSWERING WITH FIRE West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee at a government event in Kolkata, Feb. 24

ANI

aiming for a narrative of Hindu victimisation. They trotted out the old, twin charge of 'minority appeasement' and neglect of 'Hindu traditions' against the TMC. West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee fiercely countered the BJP, accusing the party of "distorting facts to create communal divisions".

On February 17, things came to a head at the assembly, as BJP legislators dredged up the Saraswati Puja charges and threw papers at the Speaker when their demand for a discussion on the topic was rejected. It ended with four BJP MLAs, including Adhikari and party state general secretary Agnimitra Paul, being suspended for 30 days.

The next day, an irate Mamata dared the BJP to prove their accusation that she had links to terrorists and the Muslim League. "If you can prove it, I will resign immediately," she declared. Her remarks that day on the Mahakumbh mela in Prayagraj, referring to it as "mrityu Kumbh" due to the reported stampede deaths, triggered fresh protests from BJP leaders, who accused her of disrespecting Hindu traditions. Adhikari responded sharply, saying Mamata was undermining Hindu faith and disrespecting the sentiments of millions of devotees.

The BJP is falling back on saffron politics for multiple reasons. The party's organisational elections have exposed deep fissures within its Bengal unit. The process of electing presidents for 1,400 mandals—comparatively a small unit—should have been a routine affair. However, complaints of coercion and vote manipulation painted a picture of pandemonium. Incumbent mandal presidents, it is alleged, prevented opposing factions from voting. These leaders, nominated by district presidents—who were in turn appointed by Sukanta Majumdar—have reportedly formed a self-serving nexus.

A DIVIDED HOUSE IN BENGAL

- **Charges of coercion and vote manipulation in election of mandal presidents exposes fissures in West Bengal BJP**
- **CBI names Bengal BJP leaders in teacher recruitment scam, among them brother of Suvendu Adhikari. A public spat shows up rift between BJP's old guard and newer entrants**
- **The BJP's much-vaunted membership drive in Bengal has enrolled only 4.1 million, against the 10 million target**

The situation was so bad that Sunil Bansal, the central BJP leader overseeing Bengal, was compelled to intervene. Although results were announced on February 16, insiders suggest Bansal remains unhappy with the fairness of the process. The BJP must now conduct elections for its district offices—a process likely to deepen internal tensions.

Adding to the BJP's troubles, the Central Bureau of Investigation has named several of its leaders, including Dibyendu Adhikari and Bharati Ghosh, in the primary teacher recruitment scam. Dibyendu, the brother of Suvendu, was associated with the TMC at the time of the alleged scam. The issue escalated when BJP state general secretary Jagannath Chattopadhyay publicly listed the accused on social media, prompting Dibyendu to send him a legal notice. The very public fight has underscored the growing rift between the BJP's old guard and newer entrants, many of whom are from the TMC. Faith-based controversies, such as that on the Saraswati Puja, have a utility then: they also deflect focus from all-too-public displays of the BJP's inner chaos.

Mamata's deployment of faith is no less calculated. That her big adversary is presently the BJP has only ensured those lavish gestures now encompass Hindu symbols. Take the development of pilgrimage sites; it's her bid to wrest back the Hindu devotional space. The showpiece comes in April: the inauguration of a Jagannath temple in Digha. Of such components will be manufactured the public consent in present-day Bengal. ■